but also potentially polarising—and will run counter to the objective of building a social coalition large enough to take it past the halfway mark in the 70-member assembly.

The Congress is betting that the hill state's partiality towards the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has started waning after a decade. Signs are that Uttarakhand has started looking past identity at common afflictions like the broken exam system, law and order, allegations of corruption, and the crisis around land, water and the environment created by a reckless growth model that's seen to generate climate peril and resource grab, but no jobs.

But on corruption, the Congress itself sported red faces after the Enforcement Directorate (ED) recovered cash and jewellery from an aide of former CM Harish Rawat on September 10. Two days later, Rawat stepped down from all party posts—saying the campaign against corruption should not suffer. The ED said the raid was related to alleged irregularities in a 2016 state exam. The ex-CM said he stood by his PA, then an OSD, and that he did not believe the charge.



Takeaways

- **Controversy on 'purification' ritual at Kharge event takes on a life of its own in poll-bound state**
- **Congress has caste justice as a key plank, seeks to rev up weak grassroots with this clarion call**
- **BJP, wary of fallout in UP, battles to retain Dalit narrative, propagandise 'Muslim vote'**

A READYMADE STORM

A probe coming a decade later, on poll eve, is indirect proof of how big a talking point corruption is. But it still didn't obscure the controversy around the Kharge episode, which has acquired a life of its own. Tracing the 'purification' rite to the fact that Kharge is a Dalit, it painted its adversary as still steeped in the practice of untouchability. It has kept up a strong broadside since. Dalit MPs raised the matter in Delhi. Protests were staged. Around 80 complaints/ petitions poured in from across the state. On September 8, a month after the incident, Haldwani police was forced to register an FIR—but did so against unidentified persons. The party had been handed a readymade plank.

Another road leads to the Muslim quarters. Estimated at around 14 per cent, they form a key bloc in the terai and a few urban centres. The party may not need too audible an outreach—loyalties are likely to stay unambiguous in this frontline Hindutva state. The Dalits, 18.76 per cent of Uttarakhand's population, present a different proposition.

The BJP is not about to give its rival a free pass to own the Dalit narrative. Such a thing has a way of crossing state boundaries—UP is voting at the same time. Distancing itself from the Haldwani episode, it chose to flay the Congress for 'politicising' it. The BSP will be in the race too, though it lost its deposit in 49 of 54 seats in 2022. The Dalit arc extends far beyond the state's 13 reserved seats, and the Congress is banking on a consolidation behind it. The idea of an Uttarakhand poll hinging on a decisive Dalit vote is, perhaps, itself a form of justice. ■

▶ JHARKHAND

The Good Ones Still Come Last

Jharkhand's recruitment tangle creates a new victim: legit recruits get the boot along with the cheats

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

Talk about life turning into a never-ending exam. Some 1,932 employees enlisted through the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission's Combined Graduate Level (JSSC-CGL) examination and 64 new Child Development Project Officers (CDPOs) went to work on September 1 without knowing whether the chairs they occupy will still be theirs when the month ends. Their jobs were cast into peril on August 18, when the state ordered a wholesale cancellation or review of recruitment exams going back to 2014. A breather came when the high court stayed that over August 20-21. Just a breather—not the slow exhalation that signals the end of stress. The cloud

SOMNATH SEN



JOB HUNTED Govt employees in protest after recruitment cancelled, Ranchi, Aug. 20